7.4 Activities: decimals

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1. Metre-stick number line

You need: a tape measure or metre stick, sticky notes.

How: A metre stick is a decimal number line: 1 cm is 0,01 m and 10 cm is 0,1 m. Ask him to find 0,5 m, 0,25 m, 0,05 m, 0,75 m. Then measure things around the house and write them in metres: the table is 0,74 m high, the door 2,01 m.

Talk about it: "Which is longer, 0,5 m or 0,45 m? Show me on the tape." "Why does 0,05 m sit so close to the start?"

2. Jumping contest

You need: a garden, park or hallway, a tape measure, a notebook.

How: Everyone does three standing long jumps. Write each distance in metres with two decimals (1,28 m). Put all the jumps in order from shortest to longest. Find the difference between the best and worst jump. Round each jump to one decimal.

Talk about it: "Did anyone jump 1,3 m and someone else 1,30 m? Is that the same?"

3. Shrink and grow (calculator)

You need: a calculator, a place-value table drawn on paper with a thick line for the comma.

How: Type 3,45 (on most calculators that's 3.45). Predict, then press × 10. Then × 10 again. Then : 100. Each time, write the result in the table and watch the digits slide past the comma line. Try to "get back" to the starting number.

Talk about it: "What stays the same each time? What changes?"

4. Till rounding

You need: old receipts or made-up prices, coins.

How: Explain the Dutch cash rule: pay cash and the shop rounds the total to the nearest 5 cents. Write prices like € 3,47, € 3,48, € 7,92, € 0,99 and ask what he'd pay in cash. Make a little rule card together: ends in 1 or 2 → down to 0; 3 or 4 → up to 5; 6 or 7 → down to 5; 8 or 9 → up to 10.

Talk about it: "Who wins with rounding: the shop or the customer? Does it even out?"

5. Decimal shop

Play "Decimal shop" from GAMES.md: a pretend shop with prices in euros and cents. He's the shopkeeper and adds up, gives change, and rounds cash payments to 5 cents.

6. Kitchen decimals

You need: packaging from the cupboard.

How: Find decimals on packets: 1,5 l, 0,33 l cans, 2,5 kg, 0,75 l. Order them. Ask: "How many 0,33 l cans make about 1 litre?" "How many 0,25 l glasses from a 1,5 l bottle?"

Talk about it: "Why do they write 0,75 l on the bottle and not 750 ml? Which is easier to understand?"

Conversation prompts for any day

- “Can you think of a number between 2,4 and 2,5?” (And then between 2,45 and 2,46…)
- “Where have you seen a comma in a number today?”
- “Is 0,5 the same as 1/2? How do you know?”